found the right fit. "There's no ego or anything."

Ego clashes are said to be absent in Dhillon's ensemble, despite recurrent rumours of a rift with Gill, who was conspicuous by his absence at both Lollapalooza and the press promotions for *First of A Kind* though he appears in the documentary prominently. Both artists have continued to express support for each other on social media, and series director Javed Ahmed claims that he never witnessed any arguments during filming.

Kahlon, who has written the lyrics of many of their smashes, believes each member of the AP machine is happy playing his respective part. "If you're going towards a goal, you need all the components to come together," he says. "It doesn't matter who's doing which job, who the face is, as long as you know what you're doing is bigger than what people say."

While Dhillon briefly admits to grappling with the pressures of celebrity in the series, for the most part, as Buttar puts it, they've decided to "roll with the punches as they come". Dhillon's coping mechanism is knowing his team has his back. "A lot of love and hate [comes with fame]," he says.

For Dhillon, the ultimate aim is to see the Indian music industry grow as big as that of the West and "to take our music where Latin music is; you don't understand what it is, but you still listen to it". ■

Amit Gurbaxani

MUSIC

KEEPING IT COOL

Sitar maestro **PURBAYAN CHATTERJEE** set out to show that classical music can be cool—and now has a transparent 'see-tar' to prove it



RAY MUDAFARE

Sometime in 2014, sitar maestro Purbayan Chatterjee set out to remind us that Indian classical music was actually pretty damn cool. After all, it's got all the necessary ingredients: there's the improvisational virtuosity that rivals the best of jazz music, *jugalbandi*'s electric on-stage interactivity, and a recent history of globe-trotting collaboration and innovation (including plenty of celebrated fusion projects by Chatterjee himself). Maybe it's just the context within which so many of us encounter this music—one dominated by traditionalists and hidebound purists—that prevents us from seeing its inherent coolness.

To test out that hypothesis, Chatterjee put together Classicool to experiment with more contemporary sounds and arrangements within the broader structures of Indian classical music. "The idea was not to mess with the content [of Indian classical music] or even to mess with the form," he says, talking over the phone from Singapore's Changi airport, on his way back to Mumbai from a tour of Australia and New Zealand. "You are just trying to create a new form so that we can highlight how cool it already is."

For almost a decade, Classicool existed as a banner for live performances, where he and his collaborators—a list that has, over the years, included Rakesh Chaurasia, Gino Banks and Taufiq Qureshi—would occasionally come together and perform. But earlier this year, Chatterjee decided to take it to the next level and turn it into a permanent band. He enlisted a younger generation of Indian classical musicians and got to work on an eponymous EP featuring tracks that blend Hindustani classical ragas with jazz, fusion and western classical elements. To give these compositions an even more contemporary edge, he busted out his see-tar: an electrified, plexiglas variation of the traditional instrument designed by Chatterjee himself and built by Belgian instrument-maker Klaas Janssens.

Chatterjee's electric plexiglas sitar is designed by him and built by Belgian instrument-maker Klaas Janssens

"I felt like this instrument really stood for the spirit of Classicool," says Chatterjee. "We're playing *raga* music on the sitar, which is a 1,000-year-old traditional Indian instrument. But the thing with the electric see-tar is that you can use an amp module or a processor to create a diverse range of sounds. So while I'm still using my traditional sitar in *Classicool*, I'm also bringing in things like overdrive and distortion, to convey different and more contemporary shades in our music."

That amplified, spaced-out sitar sound weaves its way through tracks like the live repertoire deep cut 'Pace Of Mind' (which alternates effortlessly between jazzy and ambient), the Carnatic-inflected 'Kalyani', and Bach interpolation 'Minuet In D Major'. "This kind of music can also be scaled up," says Chatterjee. "If I were to play *Classicool* in the future with a philharmonic orchestra, I could do it. The music is written in such a way. While it retains the improvisational flavour of Indian classical music, it also has that arranged structure feel to it."

With the EP out in August, Chatterjee is gearing up to take this new iteration of Classicool out on the road. He's already in talks with promoters in the US, and has an extensive Indian tour in mind as well. "The other main thing we have planned is major collaborations with international musicians," he adds. "So that we can actually bring in those flavours and elements." ■

Bhanuj Kappal